

Creative Skill Development Plan

CIM301.1: Project 1

Student Name:	
Student Number:	

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1.0 - Industry Skills Research

Skills & Competencies

Graphic designers are expected to be proficient in Photoshop, Illustrator, InDesign, After Effects. In every step of design the creative must understand colour theory, typography, layout and composition. These skills allow the designer to create static and animated content across multiple platforms. Beyond Adobe there has been an increase in demand for skills in Figma, which deals with interface design of web and app development. Additionally, drag and drop applications like Canva are used to support quick design tasks such as social media creation and mockups.

Developing these skills:

Regular use of each program discussed above allows for development in competency. As a student this is achievable as each project requires the focus on a different platform. These skills can easily be enhanced through watching online tutorials and engaging in the provided LinkedIn learning courses throughout various projects.

Currently in Demand

As a graphic designer, it is vital to have a working knowledge of UX (user experience) and UI (user interface) design (Zazz, 2024). UX focuses on how the user is interacting with the design whilst UI covers the look and feel of digital products (Garrett, 2011, pp. 2–17). This knowledge allows for a focus on the micro-interactions; enhancing user engagement by offering subtle feedback through visual cues (Nguyen, 2023).

Developing these skills:

Practice with building prototypes for web and mobile applications on Figma or Adobe XD allows for UI knowledge. Through user testing this will offer insight in the UX design into improving design functionality.

Future Changes & Opportunities

In the next 5 years, AI (Artificial Intelligence) and AR (Augmented Reality) technologies will reshape the graphic design industry (Mustafa, 2023). These advancements encourage the rise of multidisciplinary creatives—designers who integrate technical skills like motion graphics, 3D modelling, and augmented reality with strategic branding (May, 2024). The emphasis here is on the 'multidisciplinary creative', the current advancements in technology will benefit the user who adopts continuous learning and adaptability. However, learning new skills is more than remaining competitive. It empowers designers to push their creative boundaries. AI will handle routine tasks, freeing creative people to explore more complex projects. AR integration will offer new engagement for users through interactive experiences. The goals of these advancing technologies present opportunities to redefine user engagement. Ultimately, those who embrace incoming innovation will find opportunities to innovate across diverse media (Mustafa, 2023).

Emerging Innovations/Trends

There is a growing trend for motion design in brand animation and interaction. Used for apps and websites, it enhances the way users engage with the brand (Dhameliya, 2024). The uptake of motion design contributes to personalisation of the brand experience making an overall immersive interface that is dynamic (Sobowale, 2024). UX and UI design are closely linked to this trend. Through using motion you can evoke emotions, providing UX feedback and ensuring seamless UI experience (Boswell, 2023). This is the particular area of focus I am interested in. I would like to learn more about the fine details of how UX and UI can create emotion and drive engagement. To take advantage of these new innovations, I would need to develop my skills in After Effect and Figma.

Challenges

Despite AI's advantage of streamlining workflows, it introduces risk for job displacement, reduced creativity and design homogenisation (Mustafa, 2023). Meaning it can lead to unoriginal and repetitive designs, because AI struggles with capturing emotional nuance (Mazzone & Elgammal, 2019). To combat this, designers should use AI as a collaborative tool whilst still ensuring they remain central in the creative process. By maintaining a human centred design approach, AI can help generate unique solutions. Rather than relying solely on its performance to solve problems, designers can leverage AI to create a balance between automation and artistic expression.

2.0 - Industry Skills Gap Analysis (SWOT Analysis)

Strengths

My strengths lie in my adaptability across multiple programs. I am proficient in the Adobe Suite of Indesign, Photoshop, Illustrator and After Effects. My creative thinking and critical decision making abilities are strong, which align with industry needs. In particular, my decision making skills have grown due to working within my industry for the past year. As well it has afforded me with the necessary skills to appropriately manage my time to complete tasks. Working for one brand, as the in-house designer, has made me proficient in maintaining visual consistency across my designs. Additionally I take a strong interest in combining my artistic drawing skills into branding and logo development. This approach combines the traditional skill of drawing with digital applications to enhance the visual identity.

Weakness

While I have a solid foundation in drawing, character creation and animation do not come naturally to me. Often I need outside inspiration and tutorials to produce work in these areas. Improving my skills in this area would allow me to participate actively in the motion design trends, which are becoming essential in branding and digital experiences.

I have experience with using Figma but lack confidence to create effective wireframing which is required to make it an active website or functioning app. Designing visuals alone is insufficient to produce a complete outcome. I need to improve my technical abilities in wireframing to allow me to deliver a usable product. Other areas for improvement in terms of emerging tools, include procreate or AR-focused platforms. This limitation may hinder my versatility across new emerging technology.

Opportunities

I am focused on developing my UX and UI skills. This will present me with opportunities to create engaging user experiences and to complete work that raises the standard of what is already out there. The likelihood of pushing above the benchmark is becoming accessible with the rise of AI and changing to see it as “collaboration, a means to maximise both partners’ creative strengths” (Mazzone & Elgammal, 2019, p.1). Leveraging AI as a creative collaborator enhances productivity which in turn expands creative possibilities (Mustafa, 2023). With more time for creation comes the opportunity to refine niche skills that focus on details. As a result my output in potential becomes greater than what is out there, creating a competitive edge by focusing on the detail.

Threats

To stay relevant in the evolving graphic design landscape, continuous learning must be adopted. Acquiring skills in AI work to use it as a tool or learning a new program will combat against the threat of job displacement (Mustafa, 2023). The drag and drop platforms are a useful tool for designers and non-designers, however they make it harder to justify the need for bespoke designs. By further expansion of unique skills, it will work against the threat of these platforms like Canva and Wix. Another area of concern is financial, investing time and money into learning new skills to avoid a skill-gap might not yield immediate returns. This places pressure on deciding whether to invest now, later or if ever.

3.0 - Project Portfolio Vision

Specific

Learn to use Figma’s prototyping and wireframing features to create an industry ready portfolio website.

Measurable

I’ll measure my progress by first completing the design and layout of the website in the first 4 weeks. This area will focus on the UI (user interface), ensuring there is a cohesive design. The final 2 weeks will be focused on completing accurate wireframes for the UX (user experience) design.

Achievable

Using Figma, I’ll start with the achievable goal of structuring the website layout. The stretch goal is to launch the website and make it functional for the user with wireframing.

Relevant

This website allows me to acquire web development skills essential for my industry. It aligns

with my current career goals to refine my UX and UI design abilities, showcasing these skills in a professional portfolio. Having a competitive portfolio will enhance my job opportunities.

Time-Bound

To be completed within 8 weeks with each milestone tracked using the Gantt chart.

Evaluated

I will be reviewing my progress at regular intervals, focusing on the aesthetic quality. Once this aspect is completed the usability can be applied.

4.0 - Project Plan

4.1 - Deliberate Practice Plan

Goal-oriented

a. Breakdown and Milestones

- Inspiration
- Aesthetic
- Figma Exploration (watching tutorials, learning interface where necessary)
- Design Layout
- Typography Choices
- Colour Palette
- UI development/research
- UX development (interactive elements)/research

b. Session Plan

- Week 7-9: Focusing on researching UI and aesthetic, familiarising myself with the Figma interface, designing basics (colour, type) and layout exploration
- Week 10-11: Finalising the design and incorporating any interactive elements
- Week 11-12: Creating the wireframing and incorporating UX elements

Repetition

c. Skills Practice

- I'll repeatedly refine UI elements so there is a cohesive design that flows well for user interaction
- I will use YouTube tutorials for any area I don't know how to create whilst using Figma
- When creating the wireframes I will test functionality and continually improve

Feedback

- a. What will you do with this feedback?
- During class zooms I will display my work drafts and ask for notable areas of concern. I will document the feedback and adapt what needs to change.

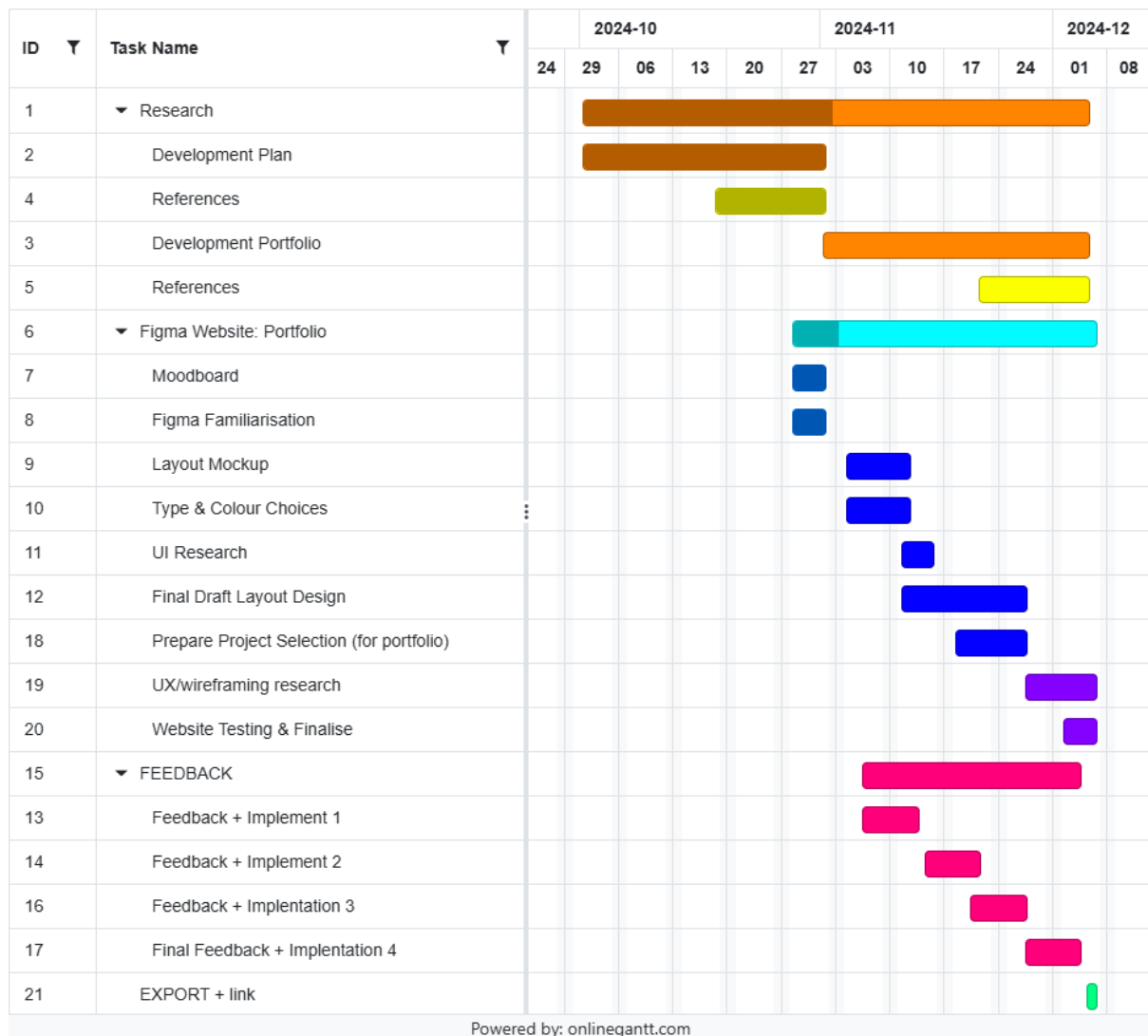
Challenges

- a. **Techniques to Achieve**
- UX and UI integration within the website. Therefore I will need to research other examples and appropriate usage of these elements.

Reflection

- I will record feedback and learning achievements. Noting down successes and challenges along the way.

4.2 - GANTT Chart



4.3 - List of Potential Learning Materials (readings, tutorials, videos, lessons)

Readings

- Adobe XD ideas - helping UI and in particular with type for web design (Morales, 2021) (Andrew, 2024) ([link](#))
- Google Design - UX and interaction design resources, "it's a guide for how to guidelines" (Google Design, 2019) ([link](#))
- Smashing Magazine, UX/UI design articles - covers accessibility and typography to user-centred design principles ([link](#))

Tutorials

- Figma YouTube channel - showing tutorials referring to specific areas of support ([link](#))

(Figma, n.d.)

- Flux Academy YouTube channel - tutorials for mastering web design skills ([link](#)) (Segall, n.d.)
- Charli Maries TV YouTube channel - tutorials for Figma beginners and insights in UX/UI design ([link](#)) (Marie, n.d.)

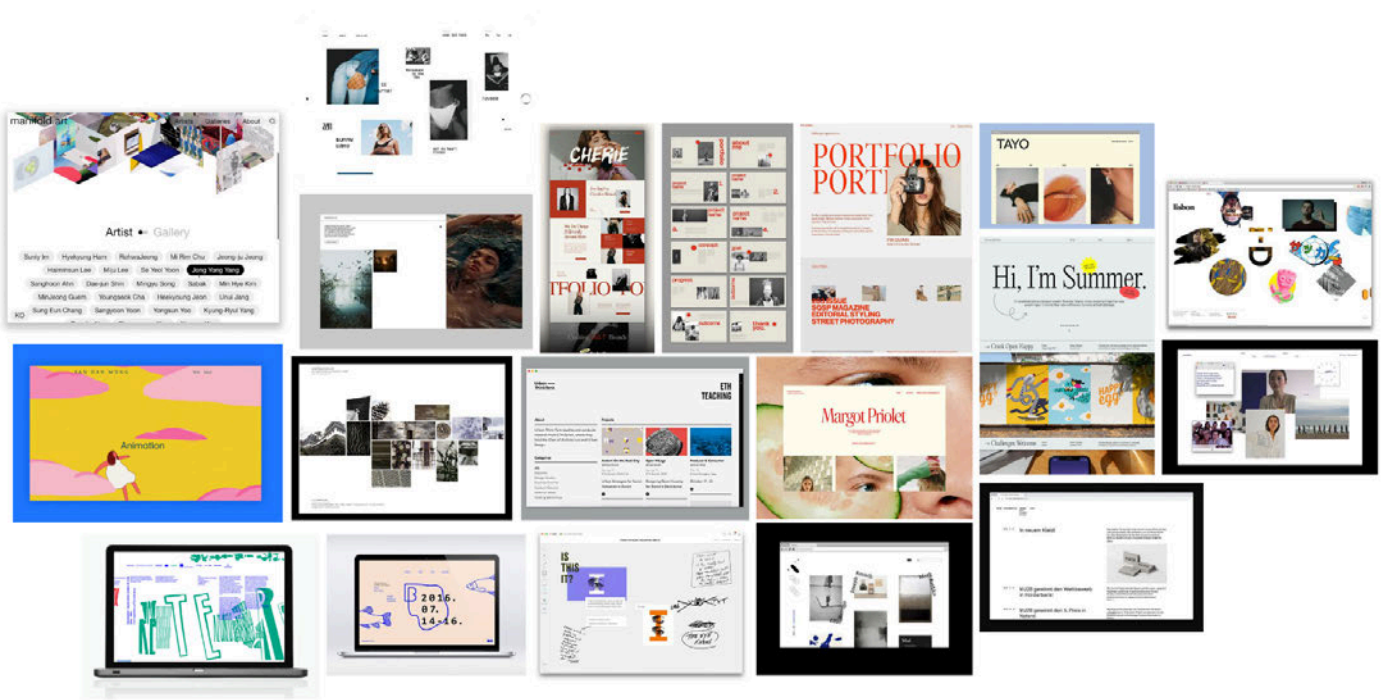
4.4 - Proof of Concept Demonstration Media Asset(s)

Web Mockup

Here is a quick mockup of a website I created using Wix. This allowed me to determine what work I wanted to display for the final product and make a start at website inspiration.

[Portfolio Wix Mockup](#)

Moodboard



5.0 - Slide Deck

Link:	
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6.0 - Video Presentation

Link:	
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7.0 - Project Checklist

Checklist (E.g. Yes or No)	
Have you completed all sections of this project template?	☒
Have you included at least one (1) APA7 reference in your Industry Skills Analysis?	☒
For your video presentation, slide deck and any other resources, have you set the share link to “Anyone with the link” and pasted the link above?	☒
Have you included your reference list below?	☒
Have you signed the AI Use Declaration below?	☒
Have you deleted all of the italicised text/prompts throughout this document?	☒

8.0 - Reference List

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9.0 - AI Use Declaration

I [REDACTED] hereby confirm that I have/have not used generative AI in the completion of this project.